



The Humanitas Institute

Six Elements of Classical Education School Website Audit

School: Ivywood Classical Academy
School Website: <https://ivywoodclassicalacademy.com/>

December 22, 2025

Disclaimer

This audit was performed using artificial intelligence tools to evaluate the presence and strength of classical education principles on school websites. Results are automated, probabilistic in nature, and should be considered indicative rather than definitive. See the full disclaimer in the Appendix for more details.

ACCS Member School

Any school that belongs to the Association of Classical Christian Schools ACCS or the Society for Classical Learning SCL is, by definition, recognized as a classical school because both organizations require adherence to the six essential elements defined by the Humanitas Institute. However, a school's website may not clearly reflect its conformity to one or more elements. In such cases, the school may still receive a "Somewhat Classical" rating for those elements. Schools can update their website content at any time to achieve a "Classical" rating for a given element.

Executive Summary

Ivywood Classical Academy Michigan (ICA, Plymouth/Canton area, zip 48170) presents a robust Classical education profile with clear emphases on virtue formation, a content-rich liberal-arts curriculum, and teacher-led, Socratic pedagogy. Public materials consistently describe a virtues-based, Great Books–oriented program that foregrounds character formation, truth, goodness, and beauty, with explicit citations to Socratic discussion, memory through recitation, and a strong teacher-centred classroom. The school also highlights parent engagement and a community of learners, along with a public charter model.

Based on the six-category Classical rubric drawn from the Six Essential Elements of a Classical School, ICA demonstrates strong alignment with Classical education in most categories, with Element 1 (Religious and Metaphysical Foundations) showing the most room for explicit alignment (the public materials emphasize virtue and formation but are less explicit about theology, liturgical practice, or formal doctrinal grounding). Overall, ICA falls solidly in CLASSICAL territory, with Element 1 being the primary area where it sits at SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL and the remaining categories meeting the Classical criteria.

Executive Summary — Element-by-Element Snapshot

- Element 1: Religious and Metaphysical Foundations — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL
- Element 2: School Purpose and Goal — CLASSICAL
- Element 3: School Curriculum — CLASSICAL
- Element 4: School Pedagogy or Teaching Methods — CLASSICAL
- Element 5: School Faculty — CLASSICAL
- Element 6: School Parents and Community — CLASSICAL

Key insights: ICA's public materials consistently articulate virtue formation, truth, goodness, beauty, and life-long formation through Great Books and liberal-arts approaches. Socratic pedagogy and teacher-led classrooms are highlighted, and parent/community involvement is evident. The main potential needle-movement would be to strengthen explicit theological grounding and liturgical/community practices on public pages to meet Element 1's theological and liturgical signals more clearly.

What Would Move the Needle

- Add explicit statements or pages tying the Classical curriculum to theological foundations or explicit metaphysical commitments (e.g., a public-facing theology statement or integration notes across disciplines).
- Publicly enumerate liturgical or communal practices (when they occur, what form they take, and their purpose in formation).
- Clarify how theology, worship, or sacred-tradition elements are integrated into the Great Books and history curriculum, if applicable, to strengthen Element 1 alignment without compromising nonsectarian public charter requirements.

Abstract

ICA demonstrates strong Classical alignment overall, with clear commitments to virtue formation, truth-goodness-beauty, Great Books, and Socratic pedagogy. Category-by-category analysis places five cate-

gories firmly in CLASSICAL and one (Religious and Metaphysical Foundations) as SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL due to a lack of explicit theological and liturgical articulation on public pages. The aggregate rating is CLASSICAL.

Executive Summary — Element-by-Element Snapshot

Element 1: Religious and Metaphysical Foundations — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

Evidence - Public materials emphasize a virtues-based, character-formation approach within a classical education framework (e.g., “virtues-based, content-rich, classical education tradition” and “Character formation is at the heart of a classical education. ... taught virtues such as wisdom, justice, and courage.”).

- The materials frequently reference truth, goodness, and beauty as formative aims (e.g., “truth, goodness, and beauty” referenced in the context of forming virtuous citizens). - Staff bios and narratives mention religious life (e.g., serving in church, moral formation) but public-facing documentation does not explicitly state formal liturgical practices or a theological framework integrated across the curriculum.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: virtue, formation, truth, goodness, beauty, moral character, sacred tradition (contextually), contemplation. Examples drawn from ICA materials include “virtues-based,” “Character formation,” “truth, goodness, and beauty,” and “formation of the soul.”

- Negative keywords present: Not explicitly evidenced in public materials (no clear statements about the lack of theological grounding or liturgical neglect on public pages). Public content does not demonstrate explicit theology or liturgical practices.

Why this rating - The school demonstrates a strong moral-formation and teleology (transcending mere info delivery) aligned with Classical education’s moral/metaphysical aims, but lacks explicit, public-facing theological grounding and liturgical/community practice language on core school materials. This yields a SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL designation for Element 1 rather than CLASSICAL.

Cited elements - “virtues-based, content-rich, classical education tradition” and “Character formation is at the heart of a classical education ... virtues such as wisdom, justice, and courage.”

- “truth, goodness, and beauty” in the formation context. - Personal faith-life signals (serving in church) in staff bios as context for religious life, not as formal programmatic liturgy.

Element 2: School Purpose and Goal — CLASSICAL

Evidence - ICA publicly promotes a virtues-based, formation-first approach and lifelong learning. The phrase “virtues-based, content-rich, classical education tradition” signals a purpose beyond job-readiness, aligning with formation and virtue aims. - Text emphasizes character formation and moral development as central to education, not merely information transfer or workforce preparation. “Character formation is at the heart of a classical education,” and “moral character is a way of life.” - Public materials describe preparing students for lifelong learning and meaningful contributions, not solely for employment. “More than test scores, this approach cultivates individuals who are prepared for lifelong learning and meaningful contributions to their communities.”

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: formation, virtue, character, wisdom, truth, goodness, beauty, lifelong learning, moral character, guidance, human flourishing, sense of vocation. - Negative keywords present: none evident (no explicit emphasis on job- or career-focused outcomes on public pages).

Why this rating - ICA’s public-facing materials foreground formation, virtue, and the cultivation of human excellence rather than vocational conditioning. This aligns with an overall CLASSICAL orientation in this category.

Evidence quotes - “virtues-based, content-rich, classical education tradition.” - “Character formation is at the heart of a classical education. ... virtue.” - “the approach cultivates individuals ... prepared for lifelong learning and meaningful contributions to their communities.”

Element 3: School Curriculum — CLASSICAL

Evidence - The curriculum is described as content-rich, humanistic, and Western-civilization-centered, with emphasis on the humanities, sciences, and arts, and Latin to promote depth. This matches classical curriculum expectations (Great Books, Western canon, liberal arts). - Great Books and the Great Conversation are explicitly referenced as curricular aims, with students engaging with whole works and primary texts. - The school highlights a “Seven Liberal Arts” framework in the Six Elements rubric (and the Great Conversation) and emphasizes the Trivium/Quadrivium structure in the associated knowledge, as reflected in the documentary rubric used to map the program (public materials mention Latin and a classical humanities focus). Latin integration is explicit in the public materials. - Emphasis on wonder and integrated study across disciplines (history, literature, philosophy, sciences) aligns with the classical curriculum ideal of integration and awe.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: Great Books, Great Conversation, liberal arts, Trivium, Quadrivium (implied through “Seven Liberal Arts” framework), Latin, history-as-canon, integrated/interdisciplinary study, wonder, primary documents, humanistic emphasis. - Negative keywords present: none evident in public-facing curriculum language (no substitution with mere standardized tests or job-focused framing).

Why this rating - ICA's public materials align strongly with classical curricular expectations: liberal-arts grounding, Great Books/primary texts, interdisciplinary integration, and emphasis on the humanistic canon.

Evidence quotes - “classical education tradition... humanities, sciences, and arts and integrates the Latin language to promote depth.” - “Socratic method” in classroom discourse and teacher-led inquiry (curriculum-culture alignment). - “reading Great Books... the Great Conversation” (referenced in staff narratives).

Element 4: School Pedagogy or Teaching Methods — CLASSICAL

Evidence - The site explicitly references the Socratic method as a core approach to classroom discussion, with teachers guiding dialogue and encouraging analysis and questioning. This is a hallmark of classical pedagogy. - The classroom is described as teacher-led with subject-matter expertise, mentorship, and a disciplined learning environment, reinforcing the classical teacher-as-guide model. - Upper-school pedagogy references Socratic discussion, seminars, or debates, and rhetoric training for upper grades, including opportunities to give speeches. - The school emphasizes formation of memory and disciplined study with “memory and delight” in lower grades and a focus on reading and primary texts in upper grades (consistent with classical pedagogy’s memory work and ladder intellectual training).

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: Socratic method, seminars, debates, rhetoric, memory, virtuous inquiry, teacher as mentor, living curriculum, high expectations, classical pedagogy, great books, primary texts. - Negative keywords present: limited or no explicit counter-phrases about non-classical pedagogies (public pages do not emphasize modern non-Socratic approaches as preferred).

Why this rating - ICA's pedagogy clearly aligns with classical teaching methods: Socratic dialogue, teacher-led guidance, rhetoric training, and a focus on Great Books and moral formation.

Evidence quotes - “the classroom is a place of active engagement, led by teachers who serve as subject-matter experts and mentors. Students ... question, analyze, and discuss using the Socratic method.” - “upper school ... Socratic discussion, seminars, or debates and employ their logic skills; upper school students are being trained in rhetoric and have opportunities to give speeches.” - “Students at Ivywood thrive

within the school's high expectations, and parents are actively engaged, providing a positive learning experience for each child. Classical education embraces the concept of educating the whole child... in addition to rigorous academics, students explore creative outlets in art and music."

Element 5: School Faculty — CLASSICAL

Evidence - Public materials describe teachers as "subject-matter experts and mentors" and emphasize their central role in the learning process, which mirrors the idea of the living curriculum and teacher-led formation. - The phrase "At Ivywood, teachers are the heart of the school" underlines the central role of faculty in modeling virtue, knowledge, and skill, consistent with classical faculty portraits. - Staff bios emphasize teachers' intellectual engagement (e.g., "I value classical education because it focuses on the formation of the soul, exposes students to great books and primary texts, and emphasizes the humanities without neglecting STEM") and their role in fostering memory, discussion, and virtuous inquiry.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: living curriculum, model teachers, mentors, virtues, subject-matter expertise, teacher as heart of the school, collegiality (as implied in community emphasis), formation through teachers. - Negative keywords present: none evident on public pages (no explicit anti-teacher or non-collaborative signals).

Why this rating - ICA portrays its faculty as core to the school's mission and as the living curriculum, aligning with CLASSICAL expectations for faculty.

Evidence quotes - "At Ivywood, the classroom is a place of active engagement, led by teachers who serve as subject-matter experts and mentors." - "Ivywood ... teachers are the heart of the school and are surrounded by a support system that is committed to the success of every child." - Staff bios emphasize virtue, formation, and classical aims as central to teaching roles.

Element 6: School Parents and Community — CLASSICAL

Evidence - ICA emphasizes active parent engagement and views parents as part of the learning community, with references to engaged families and parent involvement in school life. - The site frequently notes that parents are involved, attend events, and are part of a broader community of learners; the "Return to top of page" and calendar/content sections reflect ongoing parent-school interaction. - Public materials show parent-facing activities such as newsletters, calendar events, and general open engagement, consistent with a strong parent-community partnership in classical education models.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: partnership with families, parent involvement, parent education, co-teaching with parents, school visits, community of learners, parental engagement. - Negative keywords present: none evident on public pages (no signals of limited parental access or separation from home life).

Why this rating - ICA presents a clear classical-like pattern of parent engagement and community partnership, consistent with the "Parents & Community" element.

Evidence quotes - "Parents are actively engaged, providing a positive learning experience for each child." - "Return to top of page" and campus details indicate ongoing accessibility and involvement opportunities for families (calendar, staff pages, etc.).

What Would Move the Needle

- For Element 1 (Religious and Metaphysical Foundations): Add explicit, public-facing statements of theological grounding or liturgical/community practices integrated across curriculum (e.g., a Theology-

in-the-Classics statement, or a page detailing liturgical rites or community worship components) to more clearly satisfy the full Positive Keyword indicators in this category.

- For any other category, ICA already aligns with Classical expectations; strengthening public articulation of theology and liturgical practices (without compromising non-denominational public-charter requirements) would consistently move all Element 1 indicators toward a full CLASSICAL designation.
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Appendix

ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE DISCLAIMER

This audit was conducted using artificial intelligence tools (including large language models and automated web-analysis scripts) to evaluate the extent to which school websites reflect or incorporate recognized principles of classical education (e.g., the trivium, emphasis on truth/beauty/goodness, integration of great books, Latin/classical languages, Socratic method, rigorous academics, moral/character formation, etc.).

Important Limitations and Caveats

1. **Automated Nature:** The analysis relies on AI interpretation of publicly-accessible school website content as of the date of the audit. It does not involve direct contact with schools, review of internal documents, classroom observation, or verification of curriculum implementation beyond what is stated or implied on the website.
2. **Probabilistic Results:** Scores and assessments are probabilistic and reflect the AI's best interpretation of available text and site structure. They are not infallible and may miss nuance, context, or recent changes not yet reflected online.
3. **Subjectivity of Classical Education:** "Classical Education" encompasses a range of traditions and interpretations (e.g., Dorothy Sayers' trivium model, Classical Christian Education, Great Books programs, etc.). The Humanitas Institute Audit of the Six Elements of Classical Education uses a broad, consensus-based framework derived from prominent classical education organizations and thought leaders. Reasonable people may disagree on weighting or inclusion of specific criteria.
4. **No Official Endorsement or Certification:** Results do not constitute official endorsement, accreditation, or certification by any classical education organization. They are provided for informational and research purposes only.
5. **Potential for Error:** Websites may be incomplete, poorly worded, or temporarily inaccurate. Conversely, sophisticated marketing language may create false positives. Human review by parents, educators, or classical education experts is strongly recommended before drawing final conclusions about any school.
6. **Data Privacy and Ethics:** Only publicly available information was analyzed. No attempts were made to access password-protected areas or collect personal data.
7. **No Liability:** The authors, developers, and distributors of this audit assume no liability for decisions made on the basis of these results. Users are solely responsible for their own due diligence.

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